Climb27®

CLIMB23 TO CLIMB26

# WHO WAS *THERE*

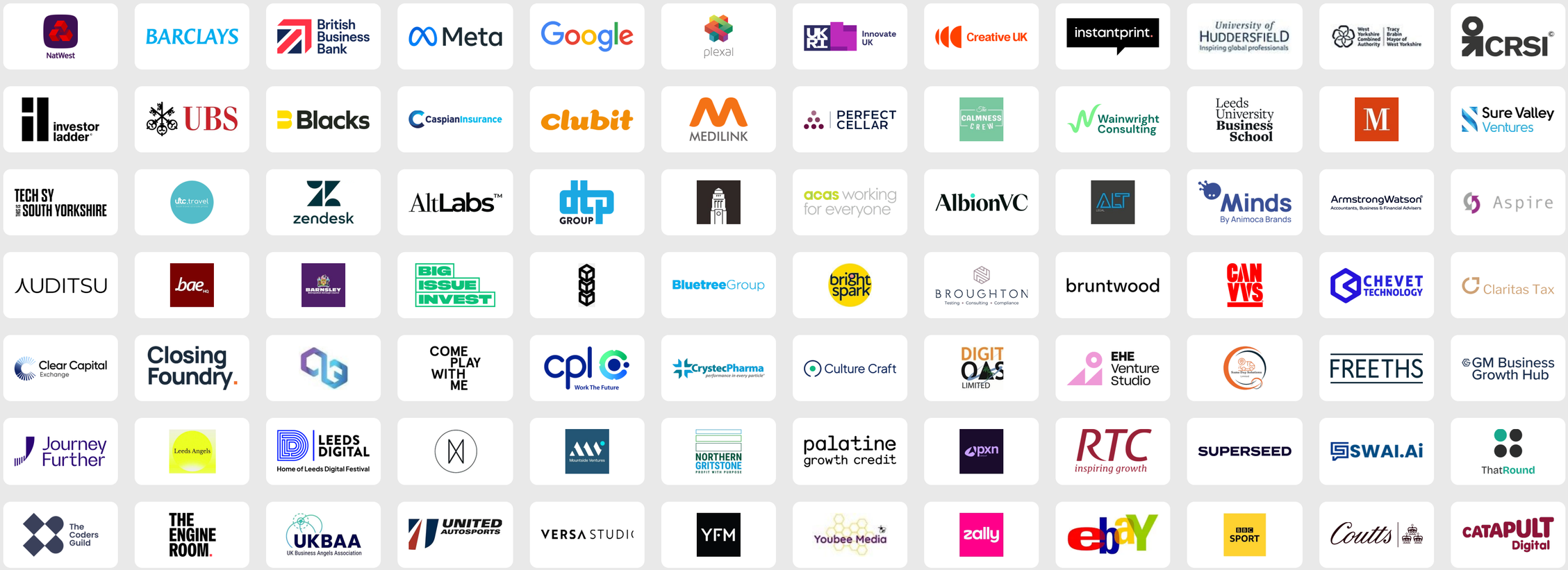
The partners, exhibitors, speakers and guests who made ClimbUK the festival for business growth, and what they said about it in their own words.



www.climb-uk.com

# IN THE ROOM AT *CLIMBUK*

Banks, funds, universities, combined authorities, global tech companies and growing firms partnered, spoke and exhibited at ClimbUK.



RETURNING PARTNERS AND GUESTS

# NAMES THAT KEEP COMING *BACK*

These organisations partnered with, exhibited at, spoke at or came along to more than one ClimbUK.

## FOUR EDITIONS SO FAR

**CRSI / Leeds City Council / West Yorkshire Combined Authority**

## THREE EDITIONS SO FAR

**British Business Bank / Innovate UK / Creative UK / Channel 4 / UBS / Mishcon de Reya / Lewis Silkin / Northern Gritstone / Innovation SuperNetwork / Plexal / Manchester Metropolitan University / Sure Valley Ventures / EHE Ventures / Lifted Ventures / River Capital / Panintelligence / Techbuyer / XR Games / IDS Group / Tech SY / Leeds Community Foundation / The Data Refinery / The Tech Dept / Mind Body Goals / Strength in you / Glean / GSG / CREATICITY / Yaba / Writebusinessresults**

## TWO EDITIONS SO FAR

- Google
- Meta
- Microsoft
- NatWest Group
- Barclays
- BBC
- Thomson Reuters
- ScaleUp Institute
- YFM Equity Partners
- Leeds University Business School
- University of Sheffield
- South Yorkshire Mayoral Combined Authority
- Health Innovation Yorkshire & Humber
- Blacks Solicitors
- Samos Investments
- RTC North
- Tech North Advocates
- Genio
- PinPoint Data Science
- Clubit Group
- Red Line Foundry
- Blossom Training
- Fourth Day
- ProspHER

IN THEIR WORDS

# WHAT PEOPLE SAID ABOUT *CLIMBUK*

Partners, exhibitors, speakers and guests on ClimbUK, quoted word for word.

**“We're delighted to partner with Climb26 and ClimbHealth as part of our continued commitment to supporting the next generation of innovators. Propel exists to help founders navigate the complexities of the NHS, to grow in confidence and then validate their innovations that will help to accelerate adoption.”**

Dr Neville Young, Director of Enterprise & Innovation, Health Innovation Yorkshire & Humber (Propel HealthTech)

**“Working alongside ClimbUK enables us to extend this mission further connecting with a dynamic community of founders, business leaders, and forward-thinking organisations. This partnership is not simply about showcasing our capabilities; it is about engaging in meaningful dialogue, co-creating solutions, and strengthening the ecosystems that underpin long-term economic success.”**

University of Huddersfield

**“Partnering with ClimbUK allows instantprint to support that same audience in a different way, by backing events that invest in confidence, leadership and learning. Climb26 brings people together in person, and print plays a big role in shaping how that experience feels.”**

instantprint

**“Our team is proud to have attended and spoken at events at Climb UK this year, as it extended beyond Leeds for the first time and headed into the heartlands of the UK, such as Newcastle, Manchester, Leeds, and beyond. For us, this isn't just a calendar commitment. It's a reflection of how we've built our business.”**

Ryan Sorby, Partner and Head of the North, Growth Credit, Palatine

**“It was so nice to be part of an event that really champions growing businesses in the UK and I've met some fantastic people this week who I hope to stay connected with.”**

Rachel Kelly, Partnership Manager, Caspian Insurance

**“ClimbUK gets this. Inclusion isn't corporate theatre. Regional innovation isn't secondary. And celebrating women who are building against the odds isn't charity, it's investment in an economy that actually works for everyone.”**

Jenny Garrett Global

WHO SPOKE

# SPEAKERS YOU'LL *KNOW*

Leaders, broadcasters and champions who have spoken at ClimbUK since Climb23.

**Tracy Brabin**
West Yorkshire Combined Authority

**Claire Ward**
Mayor of the East Midlands

**Emily Cloke**
CEO, Creative UK

**Louis Taylor**
CEO, British Business Bank

**Erin Platts**
Chief Executive Officer, Octopus Investments

**Jennifer Byrne**
Former CTO, Microsoft

**Chloe Mayirou**
Agency Partner, Meta

**Spencer Hudson**
Sky Sports

**Tanya Arnold**
BBC

**Jake Zim**
Sony

**Hugo Heppell**
Channel 4

**Simon McCoy**
News Anchor & Broadcaster, Real McCoy Media Ltd

**Stephanie Millward**
Paralympic champion swimmer

**Jamie Peacock**
Former England and Leeds Rhinos captain

**Robbie Hunter Paul**
Former Bradford Bulls captain and New Zealand international

**Jonnie Peacock**
Paralympic champion sprinter

IN THEIR WORDS

# WHAT PEOPLE SAY ABOUT *CLIMBUK*

Speakers, exhibitors and guests on ClimbUK, quoted word for word.

**“Climb is all about building connections and creating opportunities. Being able to meet with the investment community and explore what we can do in our region to increase levels of business investment or seeing businesses we have supported continue to scale and take the next step makes this one of the key events of the year.”**

Mitchell McCombe, Inclusive Economy Manager for Business Investment, West Yorkshire Combined Authority

**“This was one of the best events I have exhibited at. An amazing team, speakers and delegates. Thanks for creating such a wonderful and professional experience for all”**

Tim Bennett, Founder, Powerhouse Digital Limited

**“Climb is a MUST attend event! One of the best networking events in the UK for global business. The variety of panel talks, interactive sessions, pop-up stands provides a unique way to engage, learn and hear all things business! [...] on the back of Climb we were able to secure grants & business support from national (Innovate UK) / local (WYCA) government. Climb offers a unique experience to be able to meet with global leaders from all sectors. At Climb, you never know who you might get connected with...”**

Angus Young, Founder, Net-Zu

**“The calibre of attendees was top-notch! [...] the north knows how to do it!”**

**Eddy Davies, Founder and CEO, mutuals**

**“The energy, positivity and support in each and every room, whether presentation, workshop, socials in the square or networking was phenomenal - I saw perfect stranger connect through spending time eating their lunch together outside with us, then spend the rest of the day hanging out together. [...] I had unbelievable potential client opportunities through our workshop delivery and the quality people who scheduled networking introductions with me. Utterly loved it - thank you. Can we do it each quarter!?”**

Daniella Wainwright, Founder, Wainwright Consulting

**“...A FANTASTIC EVENT! GREAT IDEAS, GREAT PEOPLE, GREAT VENUE.”**

Jennifer Byrne, Former CTO, Microsoft

**“A day of feeling inspired and educated by so many founders, investors and brilliant people and organisations! Such a great job Gordon Bateman. Pilar Rubio and all the team! Great to see so many familiar faces and friends, too many to mention!”**

Richard Paxman OBE, Paxman Scalp Cooling

**“What an inspiring day! Bringing together so many businesses and potential investors from around the globe, to supercharge growth, really created a buzz, and showcased the opportunity and talent that West Yorkshire has.”**

Mandy Ridyard, Chief Business Advisor to the Mayor of West Yorkshire

WHO SPOKE

# FROM ORGANISATIONS YOU *KNOW*

Banks, funds, global tech companies and government, on stage at ClimbUK.

## NatWest Group

**Neil Bellamy**, Head of Technology, Media, Telecoms (TMT)
**Rita Collins**, Regional Director - Corporate Banking
**Darren Pirie**, Head of NatWest Group Accelerator & Strategic Partnerships
**Steve Sankson**, Relationship Management Lead

## Barclays

**Mark Northen**, Head of Innovation Banking
**Emma Walsh**, Head of TMT within Barclays Business Banking

## Lloyds Banking Group

**Arun Aggarwal**, Business Development & Partnerships

## Santander UK

**Gautam Sehgal**, Head of Growth Solutions

## Coutts

**Chris Dale**, Market Leader

## PwC

**Robert Leishman**, Senior Manager, Technical Delivery

## Walmart Marketplace

**Jason Perry**, Director of Seller Success

## Snowflake

**Ian McAleese**, International HR Leader

## Thomson Reuters

**Nick Glicher**, Chief Operating Officer, Thomson Reuters Foundation

## British Business Bank

**Abs Bulbuliya**, Senior Investment Manager

## Innovate UK

**Dean Cook**, Director - Business Growth and Global

## Octopus Ventures

**Jebran Raashed**, Investment Manager

## Mercia Ventures

**Chris Borrett**, Investment Director

## Northern Gritstone

**Andy Naylor**, Investment Director

## ScaleUp Institute

**Irene Graham**, CEO
**Josh Robson**, Chief Policy Officer

## Plexal

**Jessica Moffatt-Owen**, Senior Lead, Growth

## Freeths

**Malin Svanberg Larsson**, Partner

## Leeds University Business School

**Richard Tunstall**, Associate Professor of Enterprise

IN THEIR WORDS

# WHAT PEOPLE SAY ABOUT *CLIMBUK*

"Yesterday I returned to attend ClimbUK. Invited by the energy field that is Gordon Bateman to speak on a panel about later stage funding and then I ran a more intimate bootcamp on VC Readiness and Red Flags for deeptech / lifescience / uni spinouts. The panel was nicely opinionated (the best kind), with great fellow panelists, [...]. We discussed the changes by round stage, growing pains for scaleups and the need to not go through the scaling and raising phase without great advisors in your corner (like VenturePath!). [...] Maybe its the sun or my nostalgic thoughts of a younger entrepreneurial me rushing around Leeds decades ago, fuelling my optimism, but there is no reason why we can't create more venture-backed scaleup successes from across the whole of the UK, and ClimbUK was a great indicator we have the right components to make this a reality."

Ian Merricks, Founder, Proposition Lead, VenturePath

"What's the best event you've ever been to? Mine might have to be ClimbUK! The power of attending impactful events like this can be truly transformative, giving you the reset your mind might need. Not only does going to an event make you disconnect physically from the office and digitally from your computer, allowing you to feel present; but the learning opportunities and the new relationships that are forged are so so so valuable."

Ash Wilks, Director of Business Development, Wallbreaker

"You and the team have exceeded all my (already sky-high) expectations"

Gary Crotaz, Speaker

"There was a huge focus on building ecosystems which support entrepreneurship, with collaboration at their core. And how accessible and clearly signposted support must be for business owners, making it easy to access market, funding and talent (as opposed to sharing a list of topics or content and asking them to find the right place to start)"

Talitha Heaton, MPA Group

"Great event, great speakers, great participants, great networking, great engagement. Just altogether great!"

Ian McAleese, International HR Leader, Snowflake Computing

"The event had such a fantastic atmosphere of excitement, collaboration and support, and it was a real opportunity to meet people and share ideas from across so many sectors."

Nina Hinton, Director of Business and Development, Videosign

"Seeing young founders making great headways into the business world with ideas dreamt up in bedrooms was very inspiring."

Dan Boys, Founder, Wildfi Ltd

"Really insightful day at #Climb24 with lots of powerful speakers"

Rachel Fowler, Professional Services, Lloyds Bank

ON STAGE

# SESSIONS WITH NAMES *YOU KNOW*

A few of the ClimbUK sessions run with well-known companies.

**Turning Attention into Action: Customer Acquisition with Meta**

**Scaleup Masterclass with Barclays, Google and Plexal**

**Google AI Build Session With Nocodelab.AI**

**From Prompt To Full Stack Prototype With Lovable and Nocodelab.AI**

**Scaling into the US for Consumer Brands: Lessons for B2C and D2C brands from Walmart Marketplace**

**Insight to Action - Cracking the US Market with Walmart Marketplace & Infinity Blue Group**

**TikTok Changed the Rules: The New Playbook for Business Growth**

**LinkedIn ROI: What's Working Right Now**

**Solve It in Bricks; LEGO Bricks**

**Innovation Competition Winners Showcase sponsored by Barclays**

**Redefining Possible: A Fireside Chat with Paralympic champion Jonnie Peacock, brought to us by NatWest**

**Climb26 Opening Ceremony**

IN THEIR WORDS

# WHAT PEOPLE SAID ABOUT *CLIMBUK*

**“Partnerships like this are essential in creating new opportunities for innovators to connect with the right people, from clinicians and health leaders to investors and industry partners. By working together, we can further strengthen the region's ecosystem and help bring transformative solutions to patients faster.”**

Dr Neville Young, Director of Enterprise & Innovation, Health Innovation Yorkshire & Humber (Propel HealthTech)

**“If there was one takeaway from Climb26, it's this: Growth isn't a straight line. Adapt. Build strong foundations. Diversify. Find great people. Keep moving. And perhaps most importantly: Remember - you're probably doing better than you think. Yesterday was the first time I had attended Climb. I found it useful, insightful, energising and now I have lots of ideas.....if you haven't been before I would check out next year's”**

Louise Saw, Business Growth Manager, City of York Council

**“What inspires us most about this partnership is the opportunity to play an active role in a movement that champions progress, ambition, and real-world impact. Together with ClimbUK, we aim to create spaces where knowledge meets opportunity.”**

University of Huddersfield

**“Every city has its own edge and nuances, and the tour has recognised that.”**

Ryan Sorby, Partner and Head of the North, Growth Credit, Palatine

**“A big pink stand at a business expo? You'd think you know who's stopping by. Wrong! We are absolutely DELIGHTED by how many female founders and leaders came to see us. The calibre of people building in this space is unreal. And just as many allies came to find us too! Diversifying tech only works if everyone's on board”**

Girls & Tech

**“instantprint are proud to be supporting ClimbUK for Climb26 and excited to see where this partnership goes next. It's about more than printing materials. It's about backing people who want to learn, grow and build something better.”**

instantprint

**“That coffee queue conversation became something bigger. A partnership. A commitment. A belief that talent is evenly distributed but opportunity isn't.”**

**Jenny Garrett Global**

IN THEIR WORDS

# WHAT PEOPLE SAY ABOUT *CLIMBUK*

"As part of Climb, the Combined Authority supported several events supporting young people in our region. It was inspiring and rewarding to see the potential of the next generation of entrepreneurs who are bringing new ideas and innovations to the table and helping them make connections with investment professionals"

Mitchell McCombe, Inclusive Economy Manager for Business Investment, West Yorkshire Combined Authority

"ClimbUK is a fantastic event and it was definitely worth making the leap across the pond from Los Angeles to attend. There is an electric, entrepreneurial spirit spotlighted at the Climb Events and it was illuminative to attend and a pleasure to participate as a panelist."

Jeff B. Cohen, Esq., Entertainment Attorney, Cohen Gardner LLP

"ClimbUK - Climb26 rocked!!! Thank you so much. Fantastic festival promoting business growth, encouraging founders and investors and the whole ecosystem in the north of England. [...] Of course this event was an incredible opportunity for those of us selected to go, to develop our businesses and we are grabbing that with both hands, but also how fabulous to be show-casing the talent, drive, purpose and business success in the north. We are prepared to put the graft in. It was never more evident that innovation is not curtailed at the Watford Gap. Thank you Gordon Bateman and your team. You should be so proud."

Louise Thompson, CEO & Founder, Myfolks

"Plenty of very insightful workshops, roundtables and panel sessions from a great selection of speakers [...] we had an absolute blast. Looking forward to Climb25 already!"

Matt Wheeler, Director, madeby.studio

"Climb25 was truly magical and it was an absolute pleasure to be involved again this year as a speaker. All the talks and workshops I was part of were authentic, inspirational and thought-provoking, and the networking opportunities offered from the expo area, mixers and VIP drinks sessions, resulted in many meaningful conversations and countless valuable connections gained for myself and ProspHER."

Serena Fordham, CEO, ProspHER

"it was genuinely invigorating to have so many great conversations with investors, founders, enterprise agencies, government, ecosystem builders from across the UK and globally"

Barry McDonald, VP Community, CodeBase

"I met a TONNE of inspiring founders [...] It's clear to see leeds is an exciting place to be right now."

Harry Baker, Barclays Eagle Labs




# JOIN THEM AT CLIMB27

**30 June and 1 July 2027**

**Partner with ClimbUK**

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